46TH ANNIVERSARY | THE NEXT 100 SPORTS

ARM AND THE MAN

NEERAJ CHOPRA, 24

Athlete (Javelin throw),
Khandra, Haryana

Until August 7, 2021, Neeraj Chopra was just another young, talented sportsperson who carried the weight of expectations of winning an Olympic medal. A day later, he became that rare figure who didn't just meet but over-delivered on them by winning a gold medal at the Tokyo Games. India's first medal in athletics and only its second individual gold came from a throw which wasn't even his career best.

Chopra's era has begun on a high note but he hasn't reached the summit yet. Having already accomplished a milestone, the sky is the limit for the Haryana athlete. He can now focus on adding to his laurels—win the world title in his discipline and enter the small, elite league of throwers who have crossed the 90-metre mark.

Regardless of it, Chopra's herculean feat has inspired the youth and given them the self-belief that India too can compete with the best in the world and win at the biggest international sports competition. The results of that historic evening in Tokyo will hopefully be felt in a few years just as Abhinav Bindra's Beijing gold led to a renaissance in shooting. Chopra has shown he is more than adept at being the sporting icon India needs. ■

– Suhani Singh

"You should love the work you do. It automatically becomes easier to do it. I liked other sports too but chose javelin because it made me happy"

HOLD IT LIKE NEERAJ One of his quirks is to teach the correct way to hold a javelin. When he comes across someone handling a javelin not knowing which side faces the ground, he tells them the right way.